



CD-WRITERS

Once upon a time, CD-Writer drives were so expensive that they didn't feature on most people's upgrade list. But the technology behind these drives has developed rapidly and simultaneously, the cost of manufacture has dropped, resulting in a range of very affordable drives.

Today, prices of CD-Writer drives equal those of DVD-ROM drives and most budget processors. Most CD-Writers (in similar speed ranges) are priced in the same range, making it difficult to choose one. However, keeping in mind the parameters that do affect the performance and reliability of these drives, one can decide which is best suited to a particular task. While different CD-Writers support varying speeds for write and re-write tasks, there is a point beyond which the effective speed of CD-Writers does not make any real difference.

The burning decision

A year ago, CD-Writers supported speeds such as 12x write, 4x re-write and 32x read. Then a 650 MB CD-R written at an 8x speed, for example, would take about 15 minutes. In comparison, today's fast 48x20x48x drives can write a 700 MB CD in under 4 minutes at the fastest setting. However, every disk has a lead in and lead out which takes about a minute to complete. Therefore, even with faster CD-Writer drives, you would not be able to tell the difference in speeds as you would between, say, a 12x and a 24x drive. Also, you need to have media that is compliant with such high write and re-write speeds.

Hence, your choice of CD-Writer should not be dictated by speed alone, but in conjunction with other parameters such as the buffer size and the buffer underrun technology. The larger the buffer on your drive, the lower are the chances of facing buffer underrun errors while writing a CD even if you are performing other tasks on your computer. This becomes very crucial, as most of us tend to multitask.

Along with faster write speeds, today's CD-Writers also try to write more reliably even with other applications running in the background. In order to take full advantage of these technologies, you need to look for similar support in your drive's software for creating various types of CDs such as Video CDs and for creating Audio CDs directly from the MP3s on your hard disk. With most internal drives pushing the 48x write speed mark and the lowest drive beginning at 32x, the limits of speed have been redefined. Also, prices for most internal CD-

Nominees

Name	Contacts	Comments
ASUS CRW-4816A	Neoteric Infomatique, Ph: 022-24172600	This 48x CD-Writer boasts of good write speeds and technologies that let it write disk data is temporarily suspending it to take off from where stopped
LITEON 48x12x48 CD-Writer	Mediatech India, Ph: 022-56396696	This CD-Writer drive did well in write and re-write tests and its performance, it is also very affordable

RW drives are such that the variance is not more than a few hundred rupees between the slowest and the fastest drive there. If your work involves occasional CD-writing work, an entry-level 40x drive would be a good choice. However, if speed is critical, especially in professional applications, quality is also paramount, then it would make sense to go for a 42x drive that features at least an 8 MB buffer with a form of buffer underrun protection so as to prevent buffer errors. CDs while other applications are also running on the system.

In the case of external CD-Writers, the most important parameter is the interface. While external CD-Writers are functionally similar to internal drives, their performance is maximised only if your computer sports an interface that is faster than that of the external drive. The new plan to buy an external drive that supports the new USB 2.0 standard, it exploits the fullest potential only if your computer has a USB 2.0 port. Otherwise, it is limited to the significantly lower 12 Mbps bandwidth of USB 1.1 and you won't be able to write CDs at more than 1x speed. If you are going to be taking the drive with you between computers, it would also be advisable to invest in one that is rugged yet built sturdy so that it can withstand a rigorous journey on the road.

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And the award goes to...

The Winner that came out a winner this year was the LITEON CDRW55296INT-B 48x24x48x drive. It boasted of high write speeds and very good data transfer performance, excellent CD drive. Despite the fact that it featured just 8 MB buffer memory, its SMARTBURN technology ensures it reliably writes CD-Rs and CD-RWs even at the highest write speed setting.



lomega
CDRW55296INT-B
Neoteric Infomatique,
Ph: 022-24172600

The verdict: This 48x write, 24x rewrite drive boasts of best-of-class speeds and also performs very well while reading CDs

